

PAN AFRICAN ALLIANCE ENDING CHILD MARRIAGE
(PAAECM)

WORKSHOP REPORT

Youth-Led Digital Advocacy and Movement Building Convening on Ending Child Marriage

“Strengthening Youth-Led Digital Advocacy and Movement Building to End Child Marriage”

Plot 30A Woodlands, Lusaka, Zambia

7th – 8th August 2026

COMPILED BY

Wilbroad Kampolwa

Rapporteur & Technical Support Resource

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List of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Full Meaning
PAAECM	Pan African Alliance Ending Child Marriage
SADC	Southern African Development Community
SRHR	Sexual and Reproductive Health and Rights
LSHE	Life Skills Health Education
SGBV	Sexual and Gender-Based Violence
ESA	Eastern and Southern Africa
AU	African Union
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
GBV	Gender-Based Violence
HIV	Human Immunodeficiency Virus
AIDS	Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome
CSE	Comprehensive Sexuality Education
MoL	Ministry of Labour
MoE	Ministry of Education
MoCDSS	Ministry of Community Development and Social Services

1. Executive Summary

The two-day Youth-Led Digital Advocacy Convening brought together 15 youth advocates (3 males, 12 females) from diverse backgrounds, including persons with disabilities and adolescents, to strengthen regional capacity for ending child marriage through digital advocacy and movement building. The workshop focused on building technical mastery of the SADC Model Law on Eradicating Child Marriage and Protecting Children Already in Marriage, while co-designing a regional digital advocacy campaign.

Key outcomes included the draft development of an advocacy strategy, the establishment of a WhatsApp platform for ongoing engagement, and the identification of critical entry points for effective youth-led advocacy using national and regional policy frameworks.

2. Introduction and Background

Child marriage remains a critical challenge across the SADC region. Zambia has made significant legislative progress through the Children's Code Act No. 12 of 2022 and the Marriage (Amendment) Act No. 13 of 2023, which set the minimum age of marriage at 18 years without exceptions. Despite these legal reforms, implementation gaps persist, particularly regarding protection pathways for children already in marriage, school re-entry policies, and the economic vulnerability of young brides.

The Pan African Alliance Ending Child Marriage (PAAECM) convened this hybrid workshop to address these gaps by equipping youth advocates with technical knowledge of the SADC Model Law and digital advocacy skills to accelerate progress. The workshop recognized that young people must take centre stage in advocacy work, ensuring that cross-cutting issues such as SGBV, HIV and AIDS, and climate change are incorporated into movement-building efforts.

3. Workshop Objectives

The convening aimed to:

1. Build shared technical mastery of the SADC Model Law on Eradicating Child Marriage and Protecting Children Already in Marriage
2. Strengthen youth-led movement building and digital advocacy capacity to accelerate progress towards ending child marriage
3. Co-design a regional digital advocacy campaign linking Model Law asks with movement voices
4. Establish sustainable platforms for ongoing youth engagement and collaboration across the region

4. Participant Profile

Total Participants: 19 (6 males, 13 females)

The workshop demonstrated strong inclusivity, with diverse representation including:

- Persons with disabilities
- Adolescents (including boys)
- Youth advocates from various organizations
- Technical resource persons and facilitators

This diversity enriched discussions through the sharing of lived experiences and amplified safeguarding issues from multiple perspectives.

5. Key Workshop Highlights and Topics Covered

5.1 Day 1 Highlights — 6th August 2026

Opening and Setting the Scene:

Naver Chayelesa of the Madzimamwe Foundation provided an overview of the workshop, emphasizing the SADC Model Law as a vehicle to improve policy around child marriage and the role digital advocacy can play as a game-changer in the region. A Mentimeter survey was conducted to gauge participants' understanding of why the SADC Model Law matters for youth advocacy.

Deep Dive: SADC Model Law

Participants unpacked key provisions of the Model Law, including:

- Domestication status across SADC member states
- Implementation gaps and legal dualism challenges
- Protection pathways for children already in marriage
- Resource constraints affecting enforcement

Breakout Groups: Domestication Status Mapping

Groups mapped legal and policy environments, focusing on:

- Children's Code Act performance in Zambia
- Wins achieved and remaining gaps
- Protections for married children and young mothers

Plenary Feedback

Using the Youth-Wise Study Kit, groups presented findings on:

- National Ending Child Marriage initiatives
- National Gender Policy 2023
- National Child Safeguarding Framework 2023
- Education Act of 2011 and school re-entry policies
- SRHR Policy and ESA Commitments on SRHR access

Key Emphasis Points

- Child marriage is a form of gender-based violence
- The Marriage (Amendment) Act harmonized the dualism debate on child marriage by setting a uniform minimum age of 18 years

Critical gaps identified for children already married:

- Stigma: Existing legal frameworks often focus only on prevention, neglecting protection pathways for girls already married or young mothers
- Reintegration: School re-entry policies are frequently informal or poorly enforced by school administrators
- Economic vulnerability: Lack of livelihood support forces young brides to remain in abusive or dependent situations

Skills Session: Using the Model Law as an Advocacy Tool

Participants learned to translate legal text into talking points and duty-bearer asks, drafting one-page Model Law Advocacy Briefs in working groups.

5.2 Day 2 Highlights — 8th August 2026

Panel Discussion: What Makes a Youth Movement Powerful?

Lessons from existing regional youth-led movements were shared, emphasizing:

- Coalition structure and decision-making processes
- Resource mobilization strategies
- Online safeguarding protocols

Movement Building Skills Session

Topics covered included:

- Storytelling techniques for advocacy
- Campaign design principles
- Safe digital practices for youth activists

Breakout Groups: Movement-Building Strategy Labs

Groups worked on:

- Coalition structure and governance
- Decision-making frameworks
- Resourcing strategies
- Online safeguarding measures

Co-Design Session: Regional Digital Advocacy Campaign

Participants linked Model Law asks with movement voices to create a unified campaign concept, emphasizing:

- Use of regional and national policy frameworks as entry points
- Fact-based advocacy with well-defined message channels
- Engagement of key social media influencers to build traction and credibility

Gallery Walk and Pitch

Campaign concepts were presented and evaluated through Mentimeter surveys, with participants providing feedback on feasibility and impact potential.

Roadmap and Closing

The PAAECM Secretariat facilitated the setting of 6-month commitments and digital advocacy strategies, with emphasis on:

- Ongoing capacity building through mentorship
- Cross-regional collaboration with other young people
- Integration of cross-cutting issues (SGBV, HIV and AIDS, climate change)

6. Policy and Legal Frameworks Reviewed

Participants reviewed and discussed alignment of the following frameworks:

Regional Level

- SADC Model Law on Eradicating Child Marriage and Protecting Children Already in Marriage (2016)
- SADC SRHR Strategy 2016–2030, anchored on the Maputo Plan of Action
- African Union Agenda 2063

National Level (Zambia)

- Children's Code Act No. 12 of 2022
- National Child Safeguarding Framework 2023
- Gender Equality Act
- Education Act of 2011 (with emphasis on school re-entry policies)
- National Gender Policy 2023
- Marriage (Amendment) Act No. 13 of 2023
- Matrimonial Causes (Amendment) Act No. 6 of 2024
- SRHR Policy and ESA Commitments on SRHR access
- Life Skills Health Education (LSHE) framework

7. Quotable Quotes from Participants

“The SADC Model Law is not just a document — it is a vehicle we can use to drive policy change across our region. Digital advocacy gives us the fuel to make this journey faster and reach more young people.”

— Female participant, age 20

“As a young person with a disability, I felt heard and included. This workshop showed me that advocacy must leave no one behind, especially those of us who face multiple barriers.”

— Male participant, age 22, person with disability

“Child marriage is not just about prevention. We must also protect and support girls who are already married. They need re-entry policies that are enforced, not just written on paper.”

— Female participant, age 16

“Digital advocacy is a game-changer, but we need ongoing mentorship and capacity building. We cannot do this alone — we need sustained support to navigate the challenges of limited data bundles and technical expertise.”

— Male participant, age 19

“Young people must take centre stage in this work. We are not just beneficiaries; we are leaders who understand the realities on the ground. When we lead, we ensure that issues like SGBV, HIV, and climate change are not forgotten.”

— Female participant, age 19

8. What Worked Well

Inclusivity and Diversity

- Good and diverse representation with an inclusivity lens, including persons with disabilities and adolescents (including boys)
- Gender balance (6 males, 13 females) enriched discussions
- Sharing of lived experiences among participants from different backgrounds amplified safeguarding issues

Participatory Approaches

- Group work promoted active participation and ownership
- Plenary sessions allowed for consolidation of key themes
- Presentation opportunities built confidence and public speaking skills

Content and Facilitation

- Lead facilitator Taonga Zulu provided clear technical guidance on the SADC Model Law
- Rapporteur Wilbroad Kampolwa ensured accurate documentation and technical support
- Naver Chayelesa's opening remarks effectively set the scene and emphasized the importance of digital advocacy

Policy Alignment

- Review of national policy documents aligned to child protection and safeguarding in the Zambian context proved helpful
- Regional frameworks (SADC Model Law, SADC SRHR Strategy) provided broader context for advocacy

9. Challenges Identified

Resource Constraints

- Limited access to data bundles for digital advocacy for the newly established advocacy group (anticipated)
- Limited reference documents available during the workshop due to time constraints
- Poor network connectivity, compounded by heightened security measures during the election period
- Resource constraints affecting enforcement of existing laws

Implementation Gaps

- Legal dualism creates confusion between statutory and customary law in some countries
- School re-entry policies are frequently informal or poorly enforced by school administrators
- Existing legal frameworks often focus only on prevention, neglecting protection pathways for children already in marriage

Capacity Gaps

- Limited technical expertise in digital advocacy among some participants
- Need for ongoing capacity building through mentorship
- Limited access to data bundles and technical expertise constrains advocacy reach

Structural Barriers

- Economic vulnerability forces young brides to remain in abusive or dependent situations due to a lack of livelihood support
- Stigma against married children and young mothers limits reintegration opportunities

10. Achievements and Outcomes

Tangible Outputs

- Draft development of a regional advocacy strategy linking Model Law provisions with youth voices
- Establishment of a WhatsApp platform for ongoing engagement and information sharing among participants
- Draft one-page Model Law Advocacy Briefs created by working groups
- Co-designed regional digital advocacy campaign concept with clear messaging and target audiences

Knowledge and Capacity Building

- Orientation and information-sharing on key advocacy frameworks and policy entry points
- Enhanced understanding of the SADC Model Law and its domestication status across the region
- Skills development in storytelling, campaign design, and safe digital practices

Strategic Insights

- Recognition that advocacy must be based on facts, with well-defined message channels, to create impact
- Identification that key social media influencers should be engaged to build traction and credibility
- Confirmation that regional and national policy frameworks must be used as entry points for effective advocacy
- Affirmation that young people themselves should take centre stage in advocacy work, ensuring cross-cutting issues such as SGBV, HIV and AIDS, and climate change are integrated

Networking and Collaboration

- Strengthened collaboration with other young people in the region
- Commitment to ongoing mentorship and capacity building
- 6-month digital advocacy strategies and commitments established

11. Recommendations and Way Forward

Policy and Legal Reform

- School re-entry policies should be enacted into law to compel all stakeholders to allow girls to return to school, making the practice enforceable rather than informal
- Continue the domestication and implementation of the SADC Model Law across all SADC member states
- Strengthen protection pathways for children already in marriage, including economic support and livelihood programmes

Capacity Building

- Take time to read and understand policies and frameworks thoroughly before advocating
- Sustain ongoing capacity building through mentorship to address gaps in technical expertise and digital advocacy skills
- Package advocacy within the local context to ensure relevance and resonance

Advocacy Strategy

- Gather and understand ground-level statistics to support fact-based advocacy
- Identify and engage key social media influencers to build traction and credibility for the movement
- Use regional and national policy frameworks as entry points for effective advocacy
- Ensure advocacy messages are well-defined and clearly understood to maximize impact

Resource Mobilization

- Address limited access to data bundles through partnerships with telecom companies and donors
- Develop and distribute reference documents to support ongoing advocacy work
- Secure sustainable funding for youth-led digital advocacy initiatives

Movement Building

- Foster further collaboration with other young people in the region to strengthen the movement
- Ensure young people take centre stage in advocacy work, with support from adult allies and organizations
- Integrate cross-cutting issues such as SGBV, HIV and AIDS, and climate change into all advocacy efforts

Monitoring and Evaluation

- Establish clear indicators to track progress on the 6-month commitments
- Use the WhatsApp platform for regular check-ins, peer learning, and troubleshooting
- Document and share success stories and lessons learned across the region

12. Conclusion

The Youth-Led Digital Advocacy Convening successfully brought together diverse youth advocates to build technical mastery of the SADC Model Law and strengthen digital advocacy capacity for ending child marriage. The workshop demonstrated that inclusivity, participatory approaches, and policy-aligned advocacy are critical for effective movement building. While challenges such as limited resources, implementation gaps, and capacity constraints remain, the draft advocacy strategy, established WhatsApp platform, and 6-month commitments provide a strong foundation for sustained action.

The convening reinforced that young people must lead advocacy efforts, ensuring that cross-cutting issues such as SGBV, HIV and AIDS, and climate change are integrated into all work to end child marriage. With ongoing mentorship, resource mobilization, and strategic engagement of influencers and policymakers, the youth-led movement is well-positioned to accelerate progress towards ending child marriage across the SADC region.